Vistry

South Marston, Parcels R6 & R7

Bat Tree Report

February 2025

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1 The following report has been prepared by FPCR Environment and Design Ltd. on behalf of Vistry to support a reserved matters application for Parcels R6 & R7 at South Marston; comprising 137 units and areas of Public Open Space.

1.2 The development is subject to outline planning approval as part of a '*sustainable urban extension to the east of Swindon and north of the A420 of up to 2,380 dwellings together with a mixed use local centres/areas (including A1 retail up to 1,500 sq metres, services (A2), restaurants, pubs and takeaways (A3, A4, A5), business uses (B1) up to 1,000 sq metres, residential); community uses (D1); sheltered and/or care accommodation (C2/C3); two primary schools; green infrastructure including formal (including playing fields) and informal open space, landscape, biodiversity and amenity space; play space (including NEAPS/LEAPS/MUGAS); changing and sports facilities (including D2) and ancillary retail uses; sustainable drainage systems; highway, cycle and pedestrian routes; car parking; infrastructure (including utilities); engineering works including ground remodelling; demolition, site reclamation and removal of structures; the formation of new accesses from the A420, Old Vicarage Lane and Thornhill Road. | Land North Of A420 Eastern Villages Swindon*' (planning reference S/OUT/13/1555)

1.3 The following aims to discharge Condition 17 of the Reserved Matters Application which states *'Within each sub-phase, no buildings shall be demolished or partially demolished, nor works undertaken to existing buildings, and no trees on the sub-phase shall be felled or reduced, that have been identified within the Environmental Assessment as having potential to accommodate bat roosts, before a survey has been undertaken to confirm whether or not bats or bat roosts are present. If bats or their roosts are present, bat mitigation measures shall be submitted to and approved in writing by the Local Planning Authority. Such mitigation measures as may be approved shall be implemented in accordance with the approved details prior to the demolition, partial demolition or tree felling works.'*

Site Context

1.4 The Site, approximately 4.73ha in size, is located in the east of the South Marston site boundary adjacent to Old Vicarage Lane, as shown on Figure 1.

1.5 Proposals are for the development of 137 dwellings and associated infrastructure as shown in IDPL LA5979-BP-400 Rev D (IDP Group November 2024).

2.0 ES TREES

2.1 The ES prepared by FPCR in January 2017 identified three trees with bat potential, as detailed in Table 2.

3.0 UPDATE ECOLOGICAL SURVEYS SINCE ES

3.1 The Site has been subject to ongoing ecological surveys dating back to 2002. The most recent bat species surveys were conducted by FPCR in 2022 covering the South Marston area. The results of these surveys are detailed in separate reports and have been used to inform the Site assessment and proposals.

3.2 The South Marston Site was subject to a pre-commencement Site walkover on the 28th February 2024, where changes in habitats and their potential to support protect species was assessed.

3.3 Habitat lost as part of the development proposals, which offer varying levels of suitability to bats, as discussed in the following section, are shown in Figure 2.

4.0 BATS – SURVEY METHODOLOGY & BEST PRACTICE RECOMENDATIONS

Bat Tree Assessments 2022 & 2024

4.1 Previous surveys carried out in 2022 and the update walkover survey carried out in February 2024 were carried out in line with the previous iteration of the Bat Survey Guidelines[1]. Whereby trees are classified as negligible – high potential or confirmed roost.

Survey results

4.2 These surveys found that there are five trees with bat potential (1 high potential tree, 4 moderate potential trees) present within the Site Boundary. Two trees (T43 and T50) with bat potential are to be lost as part of the development proposals as shown on Figure 2 and summarised in Table 1.

Table 1: Bat Potential Tree Summary

Tree Ref	Bat Potential	Previous Survey Work & Results (2022)	Retained (Y / N)
T43**	Moderate	None	No
T44*	Moderate	2 Nocturnal surveys – no roost	Yes
T45*	Moderate	None	Yes
T49**	Moderate	2 Nocturnal surveys – no roost	Yes
T50*	High	3 Nocturnal surveys – no roost	No

*Trees identified with bat potential as part of the submitted ES

**Additional trees identified in 2024 requiring pre-commencement survey work in line with best practice

Pre-Commencement Survey Work

4.3 Given the time elapsed since the tree assessments and introduction of new Bat Survey Guidelines[2] these trees will be re-assessed using the survey methodology below, to identify potential roosting features, prior to their removal. These works are planned for March 2025.

Pre-commencement Aerial Inspection Surveys

[1] Bat Conservation Trust, 2016. *Bat Surveys for Professional Ecologists: Good Practice Guidelines* (3rd Edition)

2 Collins, J. (ed.) (2023) Bat Surveys for Professional Ecologists: Good Practice Guidelines (4thedition). The Bat Conservation Trust, London.

4.4 Any trees that are categorised as Further Inspection Required (FAR) or Potential Roost Feature (PRF) will be subject to further aerial inspection. This survey included a detailed inspection of trees for the presence of further PRF's and also for the level of suitability provided by PRF's.

4.5 This assessment will be completed by suitably experienced and licensed/accredited ecologists meeting the BCT competency requirements.

4.6 The survey will involve accessing the tree using arborists tree climbing techniques (certified to Climb Trees (J/101/2449) and Perform Aerial Rescue (A/101/2450) – Level 2 (NPTC). The climbing methodology used follows that detailed within the Arboriculture and Forestry Advisory Group (AFAG) Tree Climbing Operations Leaflet (AFAG401) and included inspecting each PRF for suitability and evidence of current or past occupation by bats using endoscopes, mirrors, torches and cameras as necessary.

4.7 Each PRF will then categorised as outlined in Table 2 and will be subjected to additional surveys where required.

Table 2: Bat Classification and Survey Requirements for Bats in Trees

Classification of Tree	Description of Category and Associated Features (based on Potential Roosting Features listed above)	Likely Further Survey work / Actions
Negligible/ No potential	Negligible/no habitat features likely to be used by roosting bats	None.
PRF-I	A tree with one or more Potential Roosting Features that are suitable for only individual bats or very small numbers of bats either due to size or lack of suitable surrounding habitats. Examples include (but are not limited to); loose/lifted bark, shallow splits exposed to elements or upward facing holes.	No further survey is required but appropriate compensation must be provided in advance of impacts and a precautionary working method statement must be applied. [A]
PRF-M	A tree with PRF's which could support multiple bats and may therefore be used by a maternity colony. Examples include (but are not limited to); woodpecker holes, larger cavities, hollow trunks, hazard beams, etc.	Three aerial assessments [B] of PRF's by appropriately licensed/ accredited tree climbers to determine presence ort likely absence of roosting bats. Surveys were undertaken between May and September (with at least two surveys between May and August and spread at least three weeks apart). [C] If roost sites are confirmed and the roost is affected by proposals a licence from Natural England will likely be required. After completion of survey work (and the presence of a bat roost is discounted), a precautionary pre-felling survey or working method statement may still be appropriate.

A In circumstances where there are lots of trees grouped together with PRF-I then further surveys may still be appropriate.

B Nocturnal surveys using NVA's may be appropriate if a tree or PRF cannot be sufficiently accessed or fully assessed.

C If the initial aerial inspection was undertaken during the optimum survey period, this can count as one of the three surveys

4.8 Should surveys identify trees or structures with suitable bat potential and confirmed bat presence, a Natural England Bat licence and bespoke mitigation will be required to remove them.

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Key

Parcels R6 & R7 Site Boundary

Wider Development Site Boundary

client
Vistry

project
Parcels R6 & R7,
Eastern Villages Swindon (South Marston)

drawing title
SITE LOCATION PLAN

scale @ A3
1:10000

drawn
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Figure 1

rev
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Key

Parcels R6 & R7 Site Boundary

Wider Development Site Boundary R6 & R7

Trees with Bat Potential within Parcels R6 & R7 Site Boundary

High

Moderate

client
Vistry

project
Parcels R6 & R7,
Eastern Villages Swindon (South Marston)

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BAT TREE POTENTIAL PLAN

scale @ A3
1:1250

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Figure 2

rev
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